

Maria, a senior at **Abakada National High School**, was excited about applying to colleges and scholarships. One afternoon, she received an email that appeared to be from the school's IT department. The subject line read, "URGENT: Account Verification Needed for Your School Email." The message explained that Maria's school email account was at risk, and she needed to follow a link to verify her account to prevent it from being deactivated.

The email included a professional-looking school logo, a link that appeared to lead to the school's login page, and a warning about potential disruptions to Maria's access to important academic resources if she did not act quickly. Given the urgency of the situation and the official tone of the email, Maria clicked the link and entered her school email credentials on the fake login page.

Soon after, she noticed strange activities on her school email account. Suspicious emails started appearing in her inbox, and a few hours later, she received a notification from the school's IT department saying that her account had been compromised. Maria quickly realized that she had fallen victim to a phishing attack.

Questions for Further Discussion:

1. **What measures could Abakada National High School implement to reduce the likelihood of phishing attacks in the future?**

The measures that Abakada National High School could take to reduce phishing attacks should include awareness campaigns and training. Seminars for the students and the staff on identifying phishing attempts should be held while providing real-world examples and simulated phishing attacks to give students a more identifiable visual than just theoretical knowledge. Strengthening security policies by implementing systems that detect and warn against suspicious emails automatically. There should also be a detection within the system to detect emails from external sources, especially those with domains that mimic or are close to the school's domain. The senders and the linked domain should then be flagged as well as blacklisted from further emails to all accounts connected to the school. 2 factor authentication could also be added to add an extra layer of security for accessing school accounts to prevent any malicious actors from doing any further harm. Designated communication platforms for announcements should also be added, and if there is already one, make sure that everyone knows that only those that are announced in the designated platform should be trusted. If the automatic detection doesn't seem to be plausible, then a way for the students to report any email with a link or accounts that send them should be added for a manual blacklist to be made. Sharing reminders periodically about

the training materials such as not clicking any unverified links or ones that come from external sources should also be sent to the students and staff.

2. How could Maria have identified that the email she received was a phishing attempt before clicking the link?

Maria could've examined the email address to see if they are different from official ones. Checking the contents of the email as well could be a great indication of a fake email as identifying if an official account of the school would send that could be crucial. Hovering over the link to see the link's full name could also prove to be useful as looking to see if there are any discrepancies with the name of the site could show signs that it is fake. She could also try to verify the email with the school's IT department using their official contact information to confirm if the email is real. Maria should also be aware of the school's policies as most schools with an online presence would likely have policies regarding her current situation.